

CLOSED — 1985 | Full Development Log

The project started from a basic 3D room built in Three.js — just a security desk, a VCR, and a dark floor. The first round of changes established the aesthetic foundation: shrinking the security room to feel genuinely claustrophobic, adding hand-painted dingy wallpaper using canvas textures, and tuning the VHS static sound to not blow out your ears. The wallpaper eventually got extended to every wall across every room in the mall, which made a huge difference in making the whole space feel cohesive and abandoned.

From there the mall itself got built out room by room — a central hub with a fountain, food court tables, and dead planters; a playplace with a ball pit and climbable play structure; an arcade with colored cabinet machines; a clothing store with mannequins and clothing racks; a toy store with shelves and a locked backroom; and a maintenance corridor leading to a backroom maze. Each room got its own lighting, props, and atmosphere. Collision was added to everything so you couldn't walk through furniture, which involved building an AABB collision system for every prop in the game.

The core gameplay loop took several rounds to get right. The idea was that you explore the mall collecting 7 VHS tapes, each one revealing more about the janitor Harold and what happened in the mall. Tapes 1 through 4 are hidden around the main rooms. Tapes 5 and 6 are locked behind a door in the toy store backroom that requires a key found elsewhere in the mall. Tape 7 is in a lockbox in the playplace that requires both the maintenance key from the maze AND having watched all 6 previous tapes — so the player can't just skip to the end. Watching tape 7 gives you the exit door code and triggers the final sequence.

Harold started out as a basic blocky figure and went through multiple redesigns to become genuinely unsettling — asymmetric limbs, visible ribs, blood smears, a wrong face. His AI runs in three modes: dormant, lurking, and chasing. Early in the game he just appears in corners and disappears when you look at him. As you collect more tapes he starts creeping toward you while lurking, moves faster, and triggers more often. Eventually he haunts hallways specifically, spawning at the far end 75% of the time when you're walking one so he's always blocking your path ahead. The look-to-dismiss mechanic means standing your ground and staring at him makes him vanish, which creates a genuine tension between running and confronting him.

The exit sequence went through the most iteration. Originally it was just a browser prompt for the door code, which felt completely out of place. That got replaced with a proper HTML keypad overlay with clickable buttons, keyboard input, and color feedback. The lockbox opening triggers a full-screen red "RUN." warning overlay with lore text. Watching tape 7 starts an accelerating heartbeat sound, opens the exit, and gives you 20 seconds before Harold enters permanent chase mode where he never stops, never goes dormant, and the safety room no longer saves you. Getting caught shows a death screen instead of respawning.

A huge amount of time went into bug fixing and polish across the whole game. The maintenance backroom maze was rebuilt three times — the first version was solvable in

seconds, the second had walls blocking the only valid path to the key, and the third is a verified serpentine design that forces four full-room-length runs before you reach the northeast corner. The toy store had an open wall leading to a black void because a door gap was cut into a wall with nothing behind it. Tape 2 was spawning inside an arcade machine and was basically unfindable. The arcade machines were facing the wrong direction. Closing the keypad was permanently breaking mouse input. The subliminal messages at the top of the screen were 11px and completely invisible. All of these got tracked down and fixed.

Final polish pass covered: tape 1 and 2 ending screens changed from hard-to-read multicolor glitch text to clean red text on dark background, VHS static volume cut significantly, death screen changed to "YOU DIED.", touching Harold at any point now kills you instead of respawning, the win screen lost its weird canvas drawing in favor of slow typewriter text hinting Harold followed you home, and the table holding tape 3 got actual legs so it wasn't floating in midair.